

# UDL for Little Learners

*A companion tool for early childhood leaders and coaches*

*A learning walk is not a scavenger hunt for good ideas. It is a process for understanding how practices are influencing learners and what conditions made those practices possible.*

## BEFORE THE WALK

### Step 1: Choose Your Focus

The clearest learning walks start with one shared question. Pick one focus area below that connects to a current school goal or a pattern you have been noticing. Everyone on the walk collects evidence through that same lens.

#### FOCUS 1 The Environment

*Chapter: Designing the Environment*

##### What to notice:

- Materials and supplies are labeled with images and words — not text alone
- Students can access tools and resources without asking an adult
- A calm corner or regulation space is visible and accessible
- Flexible seating options are available and in use
- Anchor charts are at student eye level and were built with students
- Visual schedule is posted where students can self-reference

*Wonder: Which students are most dependent on the teacher to navigate this space?*

#### FOCUS 2 Community and Belonging

*Chapter: Community and Connections*

##### What to notice:

- Student work reflects the actual children in the room — their languages, families, and identities
- Every student appears to have a genuine role or point of entry in the lesson or routine
- Greeting rituals are taught, predictable, and include every child
- The room communicates high expectations for all — not just some

*Wonder: Who is on the margins of this classroom community right now? What might be getting in the way?*

#### FOCUS 3 Transitions and Daily Routines

*Chapters: Transitions, Arrival, Morning Meeting, Closing Circle*

##### What to notice:

- Multi-modal cues signal transitions are coming (visual timer, sound, verbal countdown)
- Arrival has a consistent structure students can navigate independently
- Morning meeting offers multiple ways to participate beyond hand-raising
- A closing circle or reflection structure ends the day with intention
- Students can describe what comes next without asking the teacher

*Wonder: How much instructional time is spent managing transitions versus teaching through them?*

#### FOCUS 4 Whole Group Instruction

Chapters: Morning Meeting, Read Aloud, Phonics and Reading, Math

**What to notice:**

- Students are invited to respond in multiple ways — not only by raising a hand
- Turn-and-talk or partner structures are used regularly, with purposeful partnerships
- The teacher makes thinking visible by modeling — not just telling
- Books and materials reflect a diversity of characters, families, and experiences
- Every student has an observable entry point into the lesson

*Wonder: If a student could not read any of the words in this room, what would they do?*

**FOCUS 5 Writing**

Chapter: Writing

**What to notice:**

- A choice of tools is available (pencils, markers, crayons, different paper formats)
- Scaffolds are present as a buffet: alphabet charts, word banks, sentence frames — accessible to all, required for none
- Students can express ideas in multiple ways before or instead of writing (drawing, dictating, talking)
- Teacher language celebrates approximation as the goal, not perfection

*Wonder: Who in this room has no genuine entry point into the writing task right now?*

**FOCUS 6 Centers and Independent Work**

Chapters: Centers, Small Group Instruction

**What to notice:**

- Centers allow for multiple entry points — a student early in learning and one further along can both engage meaningfully
- Directions are visual and multimodal — a student who cannot yet read can navigate independently
- Students at stations are working without constant adult redirection
- An accountability structure exists for independent work (recording sheets, partner roles)
- The teacher is teaching in the small group, not managing the room from the table
- Groupings appear flexible — not the same students always together

*Wonder: What happens when a student gets stuck during independent time? Does the system hold?*

**FOCUS 7 Emotional Literacy and Regulation**

Chapter: Emotional Literacy

**What to notice:**

- A calm corner or regulation space is visible, accessible, and clearly taught
- Students can identify and name emotions using classroom tools (mood meter, feeling chart)
- The teacher responds to dysregulation with co-regulation strategies, not punishment
- Emotional check-in is embedded into at least one part of the daily routine

*Wonder: Which students have no visible pathway to regulation when they are overwhelmed?*

**FOCUS 8 Recess**

Chapter: Recess

**What to notice:**

- A range of activities is available — not just one ball, one game, one type of play
- Students with mobility, sensory, or social needs have genuine access to the playground experience
- Transition back inside is structured and taught — not just a race back in
- Supervisors know students by name and notice who is on the margins

*Wonder: Walk the space yourself during recess. Who is included, and who is on the edges?*

Step 2: Set Up the Walk

|                                   |  |
|-----------------------------------|--|
| Our focus question for this walk: |  |
| Walk participants:                |  |
| Classrooms to visit:              |  |

DURING THE WALK

*Come curious, not critical. The goal is not to evaluate whether a teacher is doing UDL correctly. The goal is to notice where barriers might still exist and to wonder together about how to remove them.*

Observation Notes

*Record what you actually see and hear — not interpretations. Focus on what students are doing, not just what the teacher is doing.*

| Classroom / Teacher | What I observed students doing | Barrier noticed / Question it raised |
|---------------------|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------|
|                     |                                |                                      |
|                     |                                |                                      |
|                     |                                |                                      |
|                     |                                |                                      |

AFTER THE WALK

*The observation is not where the real learning happens. The most valuable work begins when your team comes back together. Don't stop at the visible practice — go beneath the surface to understand what made it possible.*

Step 1: Go Beneath the Surface

For any practice you observed that seemed to work, push your team past the visible strategy.

|                         |
|-------------------------|
| 1. What did we observe? |
|-------------------------|

|                                                                          |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
|                                                                          |
| 2. Why might it be effective for students?                               |
| 3. What conditions made it possible?                                     |
| 4. What systems or structures supported it?                              |
| 5. What would we need to create those same conditions here?              |
| 6. Who was most helped by what we saw — and who might still be left out? |

Step 2: Debrief Protocol

Use these four questions to structure your post-walk conversation. Anchor the discussion to what students were doing — not just what the teacher was doing.

|   |                                                                         |  |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|--|
| 1 | What patterns did we notice across classrooms?                          |  |
| 2 | Where did we see evidence that students were genuinely learning?        |  |
| 3 | Where did a student struggle to access something? What was the barrier? |  |
| 4 | What can we strengthen as a system so more students experience this?    |  |

Step 3: What We Are Taking Back

|                           |                             |                                 |
|---------------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------------|
| ■ We want to celebrate... | ■ We are still wondering... | ■ Our next step as a team is... |
|                           |                             |                                 |

“You are the beginning of the story of school for your kiddos. Create a place where there are multiple entry points, where everyone belongs, where they LOVE coming to school.”